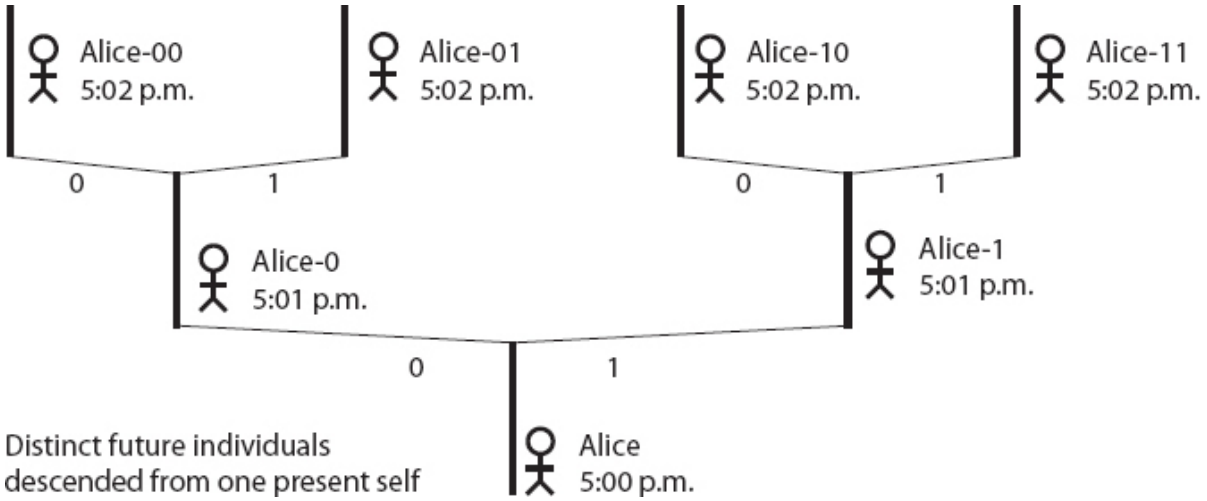
The situation in Many-Worlds quantum mechanics is exactly the same way, except that now more than one person can descend from a single previous person. (Parfit would have had no problem with that, and in fact investigated analogous situations featuring duplicator machines.) Rather than talking about "you at 5:01 p.m.," we need to talk about "the person at 5:01 p.m. who descended from you at 5:00 p.m. and who ended up on the spin-up branch of the wave function," and likewise for the person on the spin-down branch.



Every one of those people has a reasonable claim to being "you." None of them is wrong. Each of them is a separate person, all of whom trace their beginnings back to the same person. In Many-Worlds, the life-span of a person should be thought of as a branching tree, with multiple individuals at any one time, rather than as a single trajectory—much like a splitting amoeba. And nothing about this discussion really hinges on what we're talking about being a person rather than a rock. The world duplicates, and everything within the world goes along with it.

We're now set up to confront this issue of probabilities in Many-Worlds. It might have seemed natural to think the proper question is "Which branch will I end up on?" But that's not how we should be thinking about it.

Think instead about the moment immediately after decoherence has occurred and the world has branched. Decoherence is an extraordinarily